



Chinese birdcage

△ **Ch'ien Lung**, 18th-century Emperor of China

This ornate antique birdcage from China, festooned with treasures, is more decorative than practical. Featuring finely carved materials and precious stones, it would have introduced an airy aesthetic to a wealthy home.

The cage is 63cm (24¾in) high with a diameter of 33cm (13in), and is constructed from carved wood. The base is lacquered ebony inlaid with bone and ivory, and the cage features carved ivory details, porcelain water and feed bowls, and amber and jade decorations. The cage was primarily produced in the era of Chinese ruler Ch'ien Lung (1735–96), with later additions around 1880–1910.

Around the 17th century, birdkeeping was in vogue, and by the 18th century birdcages were lavish interior design pieces indicating wealth and status. Birdkeeping



Bird owner in Beijing, China, taking his bird out in its cage, c.1930s–40s, photographed by German documentary photographer Hedda Morrison

dates back to 300BCE in China, and was a popular pastime among Chinese nobility. Songbirds were particularly valued, and some cages were intended to accompany their owner around the house, providing a pleasant soundtrack, much like a modern-day stereo. Some owners took this a step further, and the ornate cage and bird were taken outside for a “walk”, a custom that continues today. The cage is swung lightly to encourage the bird to cling to its perch, exercise that helps to maintain its plumage.



Qing Dynasty birdcage, thought to have been made around 1735–96, decorated with amber, jade, ivory, bone, and lacquered ebony

In China, “birdcage holder” was a derogatory term for an idle person

Key dates

1735–1916

